Marathon Training Plan

20 weeks · km and min/km
B.A.A. Level One (beginner) · 4 runs a week · 40 → 64 km a week · long runs up to 26–29 km

How to use this plan

1. Choose your goal finish time. Use that row of the pace table.
2. Monday is a rest day every week.
3. Run easy runs truly easy. Most of your running is at this pace.
4. Start every speed session with the warm up. Finish with the warm down.

The four phases

Prep
Weeks 1–3. Build the habit.

Building
Weeks 4–9. Add speed and hills.

Marathon specific
Weeks 10–18. Practise race pace.

Taper
Weeks 19–20. Run less. Arrive fresh.

Source: Boston Athletic Association (B.A.A.) Level One training plan, baa.org. Converted from miles (1 mile = 1.609344 km). Distances rounded to 0.1 km, paces to the second.

Words used in the plan

Colours: green easy · teal aerobic · orange speed or pace work · pink long run · purple cross training · grey rest

Easy run
Conversational or recovery pace.

Aerobic run
About 20–30 s per km faster than easy.

MP
Marathon pace: your goal race pace.

HMP / HM
Half marathon pace.

10K / 5K pace
The pace you could race 10 km or 5 km.

Warm up / down
Easy running before and after hard work.

Hill repeats
Run up a 3–5% slope ("up"), then back down ("down"). Repeat.

Tempo
A steady, sustained effort at the given pace.

Cut-down
Start a little slower. Get faster in stages.

Marathon simulation
Long run with a section at MP, on a rolling, hilly route.

Cross training
Non-running exercise, for example cycling or swimming, or strength work.

Pace table

Pace in min per km. Find your goal finish time.

Goal	5K	10K	HMP	MP	Aerobic	Easy
2:45	3:19	3:34	3:44	3:56	4:15	4:30
3:00	3:44	3:55	4:07	4:18	4:37	4:54
3:15	3:59	4:14	4:26	4:40	4:58	5:19
3:30	4:18	4:33	4:46	5:00	5:23	5:42
3:45	4:37	4:52	5:08	5:22	5:47	6:07
4:00	4:55	5:11	5:28	5:44	6:10	6:31
4:15	5:14	5:29	5:47	6:04	6:33	6:58
4:30	5:32	5:51	6:07	6:25	6:55	7:15
4:45	5:51	6:28*	6:28	6:47	7:18	7:43
5:00	6:10	6:28	6:47	7:09	7:43	8:11

How each pace feels

5K intervals: Very hard. A few words at most.

10K intervals: Hard. Short phrases only.

Half marathon pace (HMP): Comfortably hard. Short sentences.

Marathon pace (MP): Steady. Your race pace.

Aerobic runs: Comfortable but purposeful.

Easy runs: Relaxed. You can talk in full sentences.

Approximate averages, converted from the B.A.A. pace chart. * As published; looks like a typing error, so use about 6:10/km. Exact marathon pace = goal time ÷ 42.195 km (4:00:00 = 5:41/km).

Week 1 Prep

≈ 39 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**8.0–9.7 km easy**
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**9.7–11.3 km aerobic**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**8.0–9.7 km easy**
Sun	**9.7–11.3 km aerobic**

Week 2 Prep

≈ 41 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3 km aerobic**
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Sun	**14.5–16.1 km aerobic**

Week 3 Prep

≈ 40 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**≈ 8.8–12.1 km hills** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 6 × (200 m up at 10K pace, 30 s rest, 200 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2–4.8 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Sun	**14.5–16.1 km aerobic**

Week 4 Building

≈ 39 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**9.7–12.9 km intervals** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 4 × 1 km at 10K pace, 2 min rest · 3.2–4.8 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**4.8–6.4 km easy**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**16.1–17.7 km with MP** 4.8 km warm up · 2 × 4.8 km at MP, 2–3 min rest · 1.6–3.2 km warm down
Sun	**4.8–6.4 km easy**

Week 5 Building

≈ 48 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km hills** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 6 × (300 m up at 10K pace, 30 s rest, 300 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2–4.8 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**4.8–8.0 km easy**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**11.3 km with HMP** 3.2 km easy · 6.4 km at HMP · 1.6 km easy
Sun	**17.7–19.3 km aerobic**

Week 6 Building

≈ 44 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km intervals** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 5 × 1 km at 10K pace, 2 min rest · 1.6–3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	Rest
Fri	**11.3 km with HMP** 3.2 km easy · 4.8–6.4 km at HMP · 1.6–3.2 km easy
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**19.3–22.5 km marathon simulation** Rolling hills · 8.0–9.7 km easy · 9.7–11.3 km at MP · 3.2 km easy

Week 7 Building

≈ 49 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km hills** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 6 × (300 m up at 10K pace, 45 s rest, 300 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–9.7 km aerobic**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**20.9 km with MP** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 4 × 3.2 km at MP, 2–3 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Sun	**6.4–9.7 km easy**

Week 8 Building

≈ 53 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km intervals** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 4 × 1200 m at 10K pace, 2 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–9.7 km aerobic**
Fri	**11.3 km with HMP** 3.2 km easy · 6.4 km at HMP · 1.6 km easy
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**20.9–22.5 km long run** 9.7–12.9 km easy · 8 × (2 min at 10K pace + 2 min at MP) · 3.2 km easy

Week 9 Building

≈ 49 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**9.7–11.3 km hills** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 6 × (400 m up at 10K pace, 45 s rest, 400 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**11.3 km with HMP** 3.2 km easy · 6.4 km at HMP · 1.6 km easy
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Sun	**19.3–20.9 km aerobic**

Week 10 Marathon specific ≈ 52 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**12.9–14.5 km intervals** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 5 × 1200 m at 10K pace, 3 min jog · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–9.7 km aerobic**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**22.5–24.1 km with MP** 4.8 km warm up · 3 × 4.8 km at MP, 3 min recovery · 1.6–3.2 km warm down
Sun	**6.4–8.0 km easy**

Week 11 Marathon specific ≈ 56 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**12.9–14.5 km hills** 3.2 km warm up · 8 × (400 m up at 10K pace, 45 s rest, 400 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Fri	**11.3 km with HMP** 3.2 km easy · 6.4 km at HMP · 1.6 km easy
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**22.5–24.1 km marathon simulation** Rolling hills · 9.7–11.3 km easy · 9.7 km at MP · 3.2 km easy

Week 12 Marathon specific ≈ 55 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km intervals** 3.2 km warm up · 4 × 1.6 km at 10K pace, 3 min rest · 1.6–3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Fri	**11.3–12.9 km with HMP** 1.6–3.2 km warm up · 4.8 km at HMP · 3 min jog · 3.2 km at HMP · 1.6 km warm down
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**22.5–24.1 km aerobic**

Week 13 Marathon specific ≈ 55 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**12.9–14.5 km hills** 3.2–4.8 km warm up · 8 × (400 m up at 10K pace, 45 s rest, 400 m down at MP) · 90 s between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**8.0–11.3 km aerobic**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**22.5 km with MP** 3.2 km warm up · 16.1 km at MP: start a little slower, finish faster · 3.2 km warm down
Sun	**8.0–9.7 km easy**

Week 14 Marathon specific ≈ 55 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km intervals** 3.2 km warm up · 4 × 1.6 km at 10K pace, 3 min rest · 1.6–3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**4.8–8.0 km aerobic**
Fri	**11.3 km tempo** 3.2 km warm up · 4.8 km tempo at HMP · 1.6 km warm down
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**22.5–27.4 km marathon simulation** Rolling hills · 9.7–12.9 km easy · 9.7–12.9 km at MP · 1.6–3.2 km easy

Week 15 Marathon specific ≈ 56 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**12.9–14.5 km hills** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × (800 m up at HMP, 60 s rest, 800 m down at MP), 2 min between sets · 4 × (400 m up at 10K pace, 45 s rest, 400 m down at MP), 90 s between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**8.0–11.3 km aerobic**
Fri	Cross or strength
Sat	**22.5 km with MP** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × 8.0 km at MP, 5 min jog · 3.2 km warm down
Sun	**8.0–11.3 km easy**

Week 16 Marathon specific ≈ 52 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3 km intervals** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × (1.6 km at HMP + 800 m at 5K pace), 2 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**6.4–8.0 km easy**
Fri	**12.9 km cut-down** 3.2 km warm up · 8.0 km at MP: start a little slower, speed up every 3.2 km · 1.6 km warm down
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**19.3–22.5 km easy** Long run at easy pace

Week 17 Marathon specific ≈ 60 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**12.9 km hills** 3.2 km warm up · 4 × (800 m up at HMP, 60 s rest, 800 m down at MP), 2 min between sets · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	**8.0–11.3 km easy**
Fri	**11.3 km tempo** 3.2 km warm up · 6.4 km tempo at HMP · 1.6 km warm down
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**24.1–29.0 km marathon simulation** Rolling hills · 11.3–12.9 km easy · 11.3–12.9 km at MP · 1.6–3.2 km easy

Week 18 Marathon specific ≈ 44 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3 km intervals** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × (1.6 km at HMP + 800 m at 5K pace), 2 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	Cross or strength
Thu	Rest
Fri	**9.7–12.9 km aerobic**
Sat	Cross or strength
Sun	**20.9–22.5 km MP tempo** 4.8 km warm up · 9.7–12.9 km MP tempo · 4.8 km warm down

Week 19 Taper

≈ 41 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**11.3–12.9 km intervals** 3.2 km warm up · 5 × 1 km at 10K pace, 2 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	**4.8–8.0 km easy**
Thu	Rest
Fri	**12.9 km with HMP** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × (3.2 km at HMP + 1.6 km easy) · 3.2 km warm down
Sat	Rest
Sun	**8.0–11.3 km easy**

Week 20 Taper

≈ 27 km

Mon	Rest
Tue	**9.7 km sharpener** 3.2 km warm up · 2 × 800 m at HMP, 90 s rest · 2 × 800 m at 10K pace, 2 min rest · 3.2 km warm down
Wed	**3.2–6.4 km easy**
Thu	Rest
Fri	**8.0 km with MP** 3.2 km warm up · 3.2 km at MP · 1.6 km warm down
Sat	Rest
Sun	**3.2–4.8 km easy**

Race day follows week 20.